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Masterminding Operations

While I was still commanding 9 Infantry Division, I was selected for a prestigious two-star-ranked appointment at the Army HQ, in the military operations directorate. For a hands-on soldier like me, it was like a dream come true when I took over as the additional director general of military operations (ADGMO) in early 1998. I had to report to the director general military operations (DGMO) and the army chief. The job carried great responsibility and entailed planning and execution of operations being undertaken by the million-plus Indian Army in the country or abroad, as also any aid to civilian authorities during serious law and order problems, or in disaster relief. During peace time, my primary task was the handling of the proxy war, counter-insurgency and counter-terrorism campaigns in J&K or the northeast, as well as guarding the sensitive northern border with China.

But I must admit that even with a service span of thirty-two years, I was a bit lost in the beginning, as I had served for only two-and-a-half-years earlier in the Army HQ. I was not very conversant with the ways of life in Delhi and its work culture or procedures. However, I made up for it with the exposure I had had in difficult border areas and the knowledge gained because of that, and could therefore make a meaningful contribution. I was certainly not a fair-weather soldier, and had a flair for fighting in the mountains and a vast experience in counter terrorism.

My eventful tenure of almost three years, from 1998–2000, has been the longest ever for any ADGMO. In the event, I served with four DGMOs and two army chiefs. The defence minister during this period was George Fernandes. The major events that occurred